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Business Psychology: Multitasking

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No modern job description is complete without the caveat, “must be able to multitask.” As a contemporary workplace credo, all members of an organization must be multitasking masters to remain competitive.

There’s just one small problem.

Science is not only split on the effectiveness of multitasking, it’s also split on whether or not humans are even capable of handling two complex tasks at once.

It would seem on the surface that humans are incapable of true multitasking. We can’t deliver two presentations at once. We can’t fill out two spreadsheets at once. We are predominantly single-task beings.

Sure, there’s simple baseline multitasking that most people attempt each day. Most would contest that adults are capable of walking and talking simultaneously. Yet time and again we find examples of people fumbling the most basic multitasking challenges:

Missing Plug-in →

Missing Plug-in →

Texting while walking is modern ubiquity. One that is a seemingly innocuous example of multitasking that we humans think we can do without incident. Often, we are proven wrong:

Missing Plug-in 

Split Scientific Findings

Information sources continue to increase rapidly. Televisions, laptops, smartphones, smart watches, and even the new Google Glass deliver a steady stream of information. We do what we can to keep up with the information flow by rapidly darting from one source of input to the next.

In the workplace, we tend to bounce between tasks at a fevered clip, attempting to trick ourselves into thinking we're getting more done because we're doing more concurrently. However, [researchers have found](#) that bouncing between tasks rapidly, to create the sensation of multitasking, may actually lower the overall quality of work performed on each task. Consequently, the multitasker will likely remember less about the tasks he performed, and will develop fewer skills as a result of completing them.

Clifford Ness, a professor of communication at Stanford, performed a field test to gauge how effectively college students were able to multitask. The findings proved, as Ness put it, "multitaskers are lousy at multitasking."

Missing Plug-in

Clifford is among the group of scientists and researchers who ardently feel the brain is incapable of true multitasking. Yet he does confess that, "The ability to consume multiple content streams at one time has [grown enormously](#)."

But while it's clear the sources for input continue to increase, there has been little consensus in the scientific community on how the brain is able to output more than one stream simultaneously.

Recently two neuroscientists at the French biomedical research agency INSERM have given us a more visual depiction of the brain tasked with two concurrent activities. Etienne Koechlin and Sylvain Charron turned to magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) in an attempt to record a clear picture of brain activity while multitasking.

The MRI results revealed that when each of the 16 men and 16 women were tested on a single task, the brain worked [both hemispheres equally](#). But, when a second task was added, the brain split hemispheres to tackle the additional task. The left hemisphere's prefrontal cortex was observed to command the first task, while the right appeared to focus on the second.

The research concluded that multitasking is feasible, but only when no more than two complex tasks are attempted at the same time. Any further amount of multitasking has been deemed not efficient with regards to brain function. To prove this, researchers added a third task to the mix and the test group made three times as many errors as when asked to perform two tasks at once.

Even this hypothesis has been met with dissention. Scott Huettel, a neuroscientist at Duke University, has looked over the data and surmised the evidence is not conclusive. "This shows there are conditions in which you can't add a third task, but it depends on the type of task and whether it draws on other parts of the brain," Huettel says.

Men vs. Women

As one might expect, even before science has agreed on the viability of true multitasking in the human brain, there has been research on which sex does it better.

A joint research project between three universities in Europe pit 120 men and 120 women against each other in a proverbial multitasking battle of the sexes.

The findings proved that both men and women were equally good at the test's singular tasks, but when asked to add a second concurrent task, a distinct divide revealed itself between the sexes.

Women were quantifiably quicker at handling both tasks simultaneously. LiveScience contributor Elizabeth Palermo noted that "their responses were only slowed by about 61 percent compared with the first task, while men's were slowed by [about 77 percent](#)."

There is little experimental evidence proving the disparity between the sexes innate ability to multitask, so while these figures are accurate within the parameters of this study, they should still be taken with a grain of salt.



Corporate Perception

In corporate terms, multitasking is code for an employee's ability to deal with interruptions.

The average office space is bustling with dozens of employees, all with separate individual tasks. Since tasks are often interconnected and dependent on multiple departments, a prudent workforce is able to immediately switch focus from one task to the next with limited mental reboot time.

Takeaway

When a job description requires an employee to multitask, what this really means is he must juggle tasks, delegate responsibility and deliver on multiple overlapping deadlines.

Having great time management skills can be a fantastic quality to nurture in the workplace. Being a reliable and attentive worker is all management can honestly ask of you.

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